

George Orwell: A Global Cultural Icon

[B2]

Considerato uno dei più importanti scrittori del XX secolo, è stato un convinto difensore dei diritti dei poveri, un fautore del socialismo democratico e un acceso oppositore del totalitarismo.



George Orwell is one of the most important writers in world history. The author of two of the most famous novels of the last hundred years, *Animal Farm* and *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, he was described by *The Economist* as “perhaps the 20th century’s best chronicler of English culture.” Orwell was born Eric Blair on 25 June 1903, in India, to a British colonial [civil servant](#). Educated at Eton, he joined the Indian Imperial Police in Burma before [resigning](#) to become a writer. He immediately started to explore the poor parts of London, dressed like a [tramp](#). Poverty was an obsession. Moving to Paris, he took [menial jobs](#) for two years. He adopted the name George Orwell for his book [Down and Out](#) in Paris and London (1933), which described his experiences.

Political language is designed to make lies sound truthful and murder respectable, and to give an appearance of solidity to pure wind.

SUPERB ESSAYIST

During the 1930s he became a prolific journalist, writing articles and reviews, as well as books, such as *Burmese Days* (1934). He became a superb essayist, especially on the British Empire, with “Shooting an Elephant” (1936) a brilliant example of his indignant moralistic [outlook](#). In 1936, he was [commissioned](#) to write about poor, unemployed miners in northern England. The resulting book, *The Road to Wigan Pier* (1937), was a [moving account](#) of living among the unemployed working class. He even went down a mine. The book was his first attempt to write plain, colloquial English for people with little education, and announced his conversion to socialism.

THE SPANISH CIVIL WAR

That same year, Orwell moved to Barcelona to fight for the Republicans against Franco’s Nationalists in Spain’s Civil War. He later called it his “[watershed](#) political experience.” He travelled with his wife, Eileen O’Shaughnessy, a poet and psychologist, whom he had met in 1935. Orwell joined the Workers’ Party of Marxist Unification (POUM). In action on the front line, he was shot in the neck and briefly hospitalised. When the POUM was accused by the pro-Soviet Communists of collaborating with the fascists, Orwell and his wife were forced to leave for England. In his classic memoir, *Homage to Catalonia* (1938), he recounted his experiences and fiercely attacked Stalin’s role in the war.

ANIMAL FARM

When the Second World War began in 1939, Orwell tried to enlist in the Home Guard, a British volunteer defence force, but was considered medically [unfit](#). Then, encouraged by his wife, he started working on what would become the

classic political satire, *Animal Farm* (1945). In his essay, "Why I Write" (1946), Orwell explained his motivation: "Every line of serious work that I have written since 1936 has been written directly or indirectly against totalitarianism and for democratic socialism." World

George Orwell e la sua riflessione sull'inglese: "Scrivere o anche solo parlare inglese è un'arte. Chi scrive in inglese è coinvolto in una lotta che non cessa nemmeno per una frase" Dietro le pagine di Orwell non c'è solo la forza delle sue visioni distopiche, ma anche una lezione sul potere delle parole e della lingua inglese. Lo scrittore ci invita a pensare e riflettere con chiarezza per poter scrivere nel miglior modo possibile. Julia Nigmatullina *Animal Farm* [made his name](#) and made him financially comfortable. A political fable, set in an English farmyard, it is based on what Orwell saw as Stalin's [betrayal](#) of the Russian Revolution. A group of animals fighting for freedom and equality see their dream destroyed by power-hungry pigs, the revolution's intellectual leaders.

HIS FINAL BOOK

Orwell, who had suffered from tuberculosis since his hospitalisation in Spain, was now seriously ill. He was also [grieving](#) the loss of his wife, who had died in March 1945. He finally found happiness in the company of Sonia Brownell, a [Foreign Office civil servant](#), whom he married in October 1949. With the final chapter of his life closing, he had by then moved to the [barren](#) Scottish island of Jura, where he wrote the final pages of what would be his last book. The dystopian *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), set in an imaginary totalitarian future, was a powerful warning about the pursuit of power [for its own sake](#). It would have a profound impact on global culture; terms like 'Big Brother' and 'doublethink' have since entered public use as [shorthand](#) for totalitarian control. Orwell died of tuberculosis on 21 January 1950. His legacy is with us still. His very name has entered the world's languages: the adjective 'Orwellian' is commonly used to describe totalitarian or authoritarian social practices. His books both described and made 20th century history.

THE SPANISH CIVIL WAR

When he arrived in Barcelona in late December 1936, Orwell was [intoxicated](#) by the revolutionary atmosphere. He saw at first hand the [enactment](#) of radical socioeconomic reforms: "It was the first time that I had ever been in a town where the working class were [in the saddle](#)." He joined the Workers' Party of Marxist Unification (POUM). In May 1937, he found himself in the middle of factional fighting between the different left-wing political groups. The campaign in the pro-Stalin Communist press against POUM had a profound, disillusioning effect on Orwell. He saw what for him was a utopian ideal of the [brotherhood](#) of man destroyed by the Soviet Union and Stalinism. His idealism was destroyed.

Barcelona has paid tribute to the British writer's time in the city with its George Orwell Square in the [old quarter](#).

NINETEEN EIGHTY-FOUR

In this brilliant but terrifying novel, one of the most influential in literary history, Orwell describes a totalitarian government that controls thought by controlling language. The state [turns language on its head](#): war is peace, freedom is slavery, and ignorance is strength. A dystopian London is now in [Airstrip One](#), a province of the totalitarian superstate of Oceania, which is always at war. The book's protagonist, Winston Smith, works at the Ministry of Truth, where he rewrites history. Winston, together with his lover Julia (partly based on Orwell's second wife, Sonia,) try to rebel against the system, which is controlled by The Party. Winston is dangerous because he wants a private life, a human life. Orwell uses brilliant fictional concepts to warn about the dangers of totalitarianism to personal freedom. These include 'doublespeak' (deliberately ambiguous or contradictory language used to [mislead](#) and manipulate,) 'thoughtcrimes' (criminal acts of independent thinking or dissent, even if only imagined,) 'Room 101' (a torture chamber where prisoners are subjected to their worst fears,) 'Big Brother' (constant technological [surveillance](#)), 'memory holes' ([slots](#) in walls used to destroy inconvenient documents and rewrite the past) and the 'thought police' (who try to change emotions.) These terms have entered languages around the world. The opening line in Nineteen Eighty-Four is one of the most famous lines in English fiction: "It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were [striking](#) thirteen."

ORWELL THE MAN

George Orwell was known for his [uncompromising](#) intellectual honesty. Critic V. S. Pritchett said he was "the [wintry](#) conscience of a generation." Orwell never let anything [get in the way](#) of his writing. In February 1946, he suffered a tubercular haemorrhage. Three months later, he [set off](#) to live in Jura, in an abandoned farmhouse, in order to concentrate on the writing of Nineteen Eighty-Four. In June 1944, he and his first wife had adopted a three-week-old boy, Richard. Eileen died nine months later. Devoted to Richard, Orwell took his son to live with him on Jura. Back in London on a brief visit in January 1947, the cold was so intense that he had to heat his apartment by burning furniture and the boy's toys. Richard remembers him as a loving father. Orwell's character was complex. Often [awkward](#) in social situations, and a natural contrarian, people commented on his courtesy and good manners. Fiercely anti-communist, he considered himself an old-style socialist based on the beliefs of the French Revolution: liberty, equality, fraternity. "Above all," Orwell once said, "I want to make political writing into an art." With *Animal Farm* and *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, he succeeded

triumphantly. And he intended that art to be for everyone, not just those lucky enough to have a good education. When he wrote, he thought, like Dickens, of those whose education was limited to the school and the public library. In his essay, "Politics and the English Language" (1946), he wrote about the importance of precise, clear, plain language. He provided rules that he thought all writers should follow. These included: "Never use a long word where a short one will do. If it is possible to cut a word out, always cut it out."

Glossary

- **Airstrip** = pista d'atterraggio
- **surveillance** = sorveglianza
- **striking** = scoccare, battere l'ora
- **civil servant** = funzionario pubblico
- **Down and Out** = al verde, senza un soldo
- **account** = resoconto
- **barren** = arida
- **tramp** = vagabondo
- **unfit** = non idoneo
- **get in the way** = intralciare
- **grieving** = essere in lutto
- **shorthand** = sintesi
- **intoxicated** = inebriato
- **brotherhood** = fratellanza
- **mislead** = confondere
- **slots** = fessure
- **set off** = partire
- **made his name** = rendere famoso
- **moving** = commovente
- **for its own sake** = fine a sé stesso
- **turns language on its head** = capovolgere
- **Foreign Office** = Ministero degli Affari Esteri
- **old quarter** = centro storico
- **awkward** = impacciato
- **betrayal** = tradimento
- **menial jobs** = lavori umili
- **outlook** = prospettiva, visione
- **watershed** = cruciale, decisiva
- **resigning** = dimettersi
- **enactment** = applicazione
- **in the saddle** = al comando (lett. in sella)
- **uncompromising** = inflessibile
- **wintry** = invernale, gelida
- **commissioned** = incaricare
- **Pier** = molo